

Thor's hammer
Small silver pendants in the shape of Thor's hammer were widely used by the Vikings as religious amulets. Thor, the Norse god of thunder, was the son of Odin, the god of war.

emitting roars and growls. We are told that they "killed people with a single blow" and were hurt "neither by fire nor iron". The berserkers' behaviour may have been caused by ingesting drugs or large quantities of alcohol and must certainly have made them difficult to employ effectively on the battlefield. But although their cult was banned in places, some war leaders are said to have used them as personal bodyguard or as shock troops in battle.

Perhaps the most objective testimony to the quality of "non-beserker" Viking warriors was their employment in Constantinople as mercenaries of the Byzantine Empire. They distinguished themselves so effectively in warfare as far afield as Syria that, from the late 10th century, they were formed into the emperor's elite Varangian Guard. Naturally the Byzantines liked to patronize these foreign mercenaries, describing them as "axe-bearing barbarians". Their drunkenness was as much an object of astonishment to their sophisticated hosts as their fierceness in combat. But it was for their strength and loyalty that they were prized and often liberally rewarded.

LATER VIKING CONQUESTS

Relatively quiescent through much of the 10th century, Viking power underwent a resurgence from the 980s. Anglo-Saxon Britain suffered the aggressive raids of the fearsome Olaf Trygvasson, followed in the second decade of the 11th century by the conquest that made Norwegian King Cnut ruler of England. For a time Cnut ruled Denmark also, creating a shortlived North Sea empire. But this turned out to be a late flowering of Viking influence. In 1066 the Norwegian King Harald Hardrada, a formidable warrior who, during a period of exile, had served in Constantinople in the Varangian Guard, invaded Britain to uphold his claim to the royal succession, but was defeated at Stamford Bridge by Anglo-Saxon King Harold. Ironically, Harold was then defeated at the battle of Hastings by the Normans, descendants of the Vikings who had by then become French in language and culture.

> "YOU WORKED WELL IN THE SHIELD-WAR, WARRIOR-KING; BROWN WAS THE FLESH OF BODIES SERVED TO THE BLOOD-BIRD: IN THE SLAUGHTER, YOU WON, SIRE, WITH YOUR SWORD ENOUGH OF A NAME..."
>
> *KNYTLINGA SAGA*, DESCRIBING KING CNUT WARRING IN ENGLAND, PROBABLY WRITTEN AROUND 1250



Warriors' resting place
The burial ground at Lindholm Høje in northern Denmark contains over 700 graves dating from about 700–1100 CE. The bodies were cremated, but grave goods show that men's graves were marked by stones arranged in the shape of ships.